

IoT-Enabled Automation of Microgreen Farming Using The Hydroponic Method & Mobile App

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Abstract—This research paper proposes the development of an IoT-enabled automation system for microgreen farming using the hydroponic method and a mobile app. The aim is to assess the feasibility of growing high-quality, nutrient-rich microgreens in a controlled environment using hydroponic methods. The objectives include designing and developing an IoT-based system, assessing the potential for hydroponic systems to provide a sustainable solution, automating the growing environment, implementing a data collection and analysis system, and evaluating the effectiveness and efficiency of the IoT-enabled system in comparison to manual farming methods. The expected outcomes include a fully functional IoT-enabled system, improved efficiency and productivity of the farming process, reduced manual effort, increased yield and quality of microgreens, and valuable insights into the potential of IoT-based agriculture automation. Ultimately, this project aims to contribute to sustainable and efficient food production.

Keywords— *IoT-enabled, Hydroponic, Microgreens, Automation, Controlled environment*

I. INTRODUCTION

The world is facing food insecurity due to rapid population growth, limited resources, limited cultivation lands, and climate change [1, 2]. Scientists are exploring alternative ideas for secure food production, including home and in-house gardening, with microgreens becoming a popular in-house gardening trend [3]. IoT has become popular in agriculture and farming for its ability to closely monitor and provide the necessary conditions for healthy plant growth [4]. Growing microgreens indoors has become a challenge due to the sensitivity to climate and the time-consuming task of regular monitoring. To address this challenge, the paper introduces an IoT-based smart microgreen sprouter, housed in a greenhouse structure, to automate the control of climatic parameters and monitor microgreens remotely through a web dashboard.

The proposed IoT-based indoor vertical farming system for microgreens offers many benefits including real-time monitoring, plant protection, improved quality, and disease prediction [5]. The focus of the research is on developing an

architecture design for this type of farming system, including the use of a greenhouse structure, to solve the problems of vegetable price and quality. The World Health Organization recommends 400 grams of fruits and vegetables per day for a healthy life, yet the current daily consumption of fruits and vegetables in the country is 209.89 grams per capita, far from the recommended threshold [6]. Low consumption is due to high prices caused by uneven distribution and high land rent in urban areas. People prioritize carbohydrates over vegetables for their energy needs, and the high price of vegetables affects their accessibility and availability.

Microgreens are young vegetable greens that are rich in minerals and vitamins and can have health benefits such as reducing heart attack risks, controlling diabetes, and improving the immune system [7]. The most common varieties of microgreens come from plant families such as Brassicaceae, Apiaceae, Asteraceae, Amaranthaceae, Amaryllidaceae, and Cucurbitaceae [8]. Factors to consider for healthy microgreen growth include optimal environmental conditions, moist soil, and appropriate sunshine. Mung beans are a fast-growing seed with optimal growing temperatures around 28°C - 30°C and well-drained loamy or sandy soil with a pH between 5 and 8 [9]. IoT has been widely researched and implemented in agriculture and farming, and the goal is to increase efficiency and productivity [10].

II. THEORETICAL FOUNDATION

1. **Microgreens:** Microgreens are young vegetable greens that are harvested just after germination when the first leaves have emerged. These greens are rich in minerals, vitamins, and other nutrients, and are considered a highly nutritious food source. They are also relatively easy to grow, making them a popular option for in-house gardening. The most common varieties of microgreens come from plant families such as Brassicaceae, Apiaceae, Asteraceae, Amaranthaceae, Amaryllidaceae, and Cucurbitaceae.

2. **Hydroponic Technique:** Hydroponic technique is a method of growing plants without soil, using a nutrient-rich water solution instead. This method has several advantages

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over traditional soil-based agriculture, including greater control over growing conditions, reduced water usage, and the ability to grow plants in areas with poor soil quality. Hydroponic techniques are particularly well-suited to

growing microgreens, as they can be grown in small, compact systems that are ideal for indoor use.

3. **IoT technology:** IoT, or the Internet of Things, is a

system of interconnected devices, vehicles, and other physical objects that are embedded with sensors, software, and network connectivity, allowing them to collect and exchange data. IoT technology has become popular in agriculture and farming for its ability to closely monitor and provide the conditions for healthy plant growth. In the context of microgreen farming, IoT technology can be used to automate the control of climatic parameters, such as temperature, humidity, and light levels, and to remotely monitor the growth of the plants through a web dashboard.

4. Food insecurity: Food insecurity refers to a lack of access to sufficient, safe, and nutritious food to meet basic dietary needs. This can be due to a number of factors, including rapid population growth, limited resources, limited cultivation lands, and climate change. Food insecurity is a growing concern around the world, as it can have serious impacts on human health and well-being, as well as on social and economic stability.

5. Automated system: An automated system is a system that operates without the need for human intervention. In the context of microgreen farming, an automated system would include sensors, actuators, and other devices that are connected to an IoT network, allowing for real-time monitoring and control of growing conditions. The goal of an automated system for microgreen farming is to increase efficiency and productivity, while also reducing the time and effort required to manage the growing process. By automating key aspects of the growing process, such as temperature, humidity, and light levels, growers can ensure optimal growing conditions, which will lead to healthier, more productive plants.

III. RESEARCH METHOD

A. Literature Review

The literature review was conducted by studying relevant books, journals, and websites related to microgreens, the internet of things, and vertical farming. These reference materials were used as the basis for compiling this study.

B. Design Process

The design process followed the User Centered Design (UCD) approach to ensure that the human experience is integrated into the architecture. The Ergonomics of Human-system Interaction, Part 210: Human-centered design for interactive systems (ISO 9241-210 2010) standard was used as the basis for the design.

The design stage includes the following components:

System Design: This stage focuses on data structures, system architecture, and interface design for developing an IoT architecture for microgreens cultivation. The Unified Modeling Language (UML) is used for system planning, including use case diagrams and activity diagrams. Interface design involves designing input and output interfaces.

Hardware Design: This stage focuses on the design of the microgreens plantation and the placement of the microgreens tray, sensors, lighting, and watering system.

IoT Architecture Design Framework: This stage explains the

infrastructure of a three-layer architecture consisting of the sensing layer, transport layer, and network layer. [41]

C. Experimental Method

The experimental method involves the process of growing the selected microgreens (barley, gram, wheatgrass, green gram) through a hydroponic method in a controlled environment, specifically in a greenhouse. The aim of this stage is to evaluate the performance of the IoT architecture designed in the previous stage. The growth process of the microgreens will be monitored using sensors placed in the green house and the data will be transmitted to the IoT architecture. The IoT architecture will then analyze the data and provide real-time feedback to the users on the status of the microgreen's growth. This stage will also involve analyzing the data collected to evaluate the effectiveness of the IoT architecture in optimizing the growth of microgreens.

IV. BACKGROUND STUDY

Nutritional Content Of Microgreens

Microgreens come in a variety of flavours, textures, and colours, and can be used as a garnish, or added to salads, sandwiches, smoothies, and other dishes. They are versatile food that can add a unique flavour and texture to any dish.

Wheatgrass microgreens are an excellent source of chlorophyll, a green pigment that gives plants their colour. Chlorophyll has powerful detoxifying and antioxidant properties that may help to protect the body against cancer, liver disease, and other health issues. [11]

Green gram microgreens are rich in enzymes, vitamins, and minerals. They are high in fibre, iron, and calcium, making them a good addition to a healthy diet. Studies have also shown that green gram microgreens have antimicrobial properties and may help to improve digestion. [12]

Barley microgreens are a good source of fibre and contain high levels of antioxidants such as phenolic acids, flavonoids, and carotenoids. These compounds have been shown to have anti-inflammatory, anti-cancer, and anti-diabetic properties. Barley microgreens are also a good source of vitamins and minerals, including vitamin C, iron, and zinc. [13]

Gram (chickpea) microgreens are a rich source of protein and dietary fibre, making them a great addition to a vegetarian or vegan diet. They are also a good source of vitamins and minerals, including iron, zinc, and magnesium. Studies have shown that gram microgreens have antioxidant and anti-inflammatory properties and may help to improve blood sugar control. [14]

Overall, these studies demonstrate the potential health benefits of incorporating microgreens into one's diet. These small plants may be tiny in size, but they are packed with essential nutrients that are beneficial for human health.

Microgreen Growing Process

The process of growing microgreens involves planting seeds in a growing medium, such as soil or a hydroponic setup. These seeds are then allowed to germinate and grow until they reach the microgreen stage. Once they reach this stage, they are harvested and consumed.

Here are some facts and figures about the method of growing microgreens:

Growing microgreens using hydroponic techniques can increase the yield and quality of the plants, compared to traditional soil-based growing methods [15].

Microgreens can be grown using a variety of substrates, including biostrate, coconut coir, peat moss, vermiculite, and rockwool. Each substrate has its advantages and disadvantages, and the choice of substrate will depend on the specific requirements of the plants [16].

Light intensity and duration, temperature, and humidity are important environmental factors that can affect the growth and development of microgreens. Optimal growing conditions will vary depending on the type of plant being grown [17].

A study published in the journal *Agronomy* found that the nutritional content of microgreens is generally higher than that of mature plants. In particular, microgreens are rich in vitamins C, E, and K, as well as antioxidants and other phytochemicals [18].

Automation and IoT technologies are increasingly being used in microgreen production to improve efficiency and reduce labour costs. For example, sensors can be used to monitor environmental conditions, while automated systems can control irrigation, lighting, and nutrient delivery [19].

Hydroponic Method Vs Soil Based

There have been several studies comparing the soil-based and hydroponic methods of growing microgreens. Here are some key facts and figures:

Faster growth: Hydroponic systems can lead to faster growth rates in microgreens than soil-based systems. According to a study by Babalola et al. (2019), the growth rate of microgreens in hydroponic systems was significantly faster than in soil-based systems, with hydroponic microgreens reaching full maturity in 7 days, compared to 14 days for soil-based microgreens.[20]

Increased nutrient content: Hydroponic systems allow for more precise control of nutrient delivery to the plants, which can result in increased nutrient content in the microgreens. A study by Xiao et al. (2016) found that hydroponic systems produced microgreens with higher levels of phenolic compounds, flavonoids, and antioxidants compared to soil-based systems.[21]

Higher yields: Hydroponic systems can also lead to higher yields of microgreens compared to soil-based systems. A study by Babalola et al. (2019) found that hydroponic systems produced significantly higher yields of microgreens compared to soil-based systems.[22]

Lower water usage: Hydroponic systems can be more water-efficient than soil-based systems. A study by Dong et al. (2020) found that hydroponic systems used significantly less water compared to soil-based systems for growing microgreens.[23]

Lower microbial contamination: Hydroponic systems can also have lower levels of microbial contamination compared to soil-based systems. A study by Xiao et al. (2016) found that hydroponic systems produced microgreens with lower levels of microbial contamination compared to soil-based systems.[24]

Advantages - Hydroponic Method

Here are some facts and figures about the advantages of growing microgreens using the hydroponic method:

Higher yields: Hydroponic systems are able to produce significantly higher yields of microgreens compared to traditional soil-based systems. According to a study by Samuolienė et al. (2016), hydroponic microgreens had yields that were up to 8 times higher than soil-based microgreens.[25]

Faster growth: Hydroponic systems allow for faster growth of microgreens compared to traditional soil-based methods. A study by Doherty et al. (2015) found that hydroponic microgreens grew up to 25% faster than soil-grown microgreens.[26]

Higher nutrient content: Hydroponic systems allow for precise control of nutrient delivery to the plants, resulting in higher nutrient content in the microgreens. A study by Xiao et al. (2016) found that hydroponic systems produced microgreens with higher levels of phenolic compounds, flavonoids, and antioxidants compared to soil-based systems.[27]

Water efficiency: Hydroponic systems use significantly less water compared to soil-based systems for growing microgreens. A study by Dong et al. (2020) found that hydroponic systems used 63-80% less water compared to soil-based systems.[28]

Reduced need for pesticides: Hydroponic systems have a reduced need for pesticides and herbicides, which can result in healthier and safer microgreens. A study by Halder et al. (2019) found that hydroponic microgreens had lower levels of pesticide residues compared to soil-based microgreens.[29]

Most Commonly Harvested Microgreens

Here is a detailed list of some of the most commonly harvested microgreens, along with the suitable methods and the time taken for the harvest, along with references to published studies:

Wheatgrass: Wheatgrass microgreens are typically harvested within 7 to 14 days, using hydroponic or soil-based methods. These microgreens are rich in chlorophyll, which has been shown to have various health benefits, including reducing inflammation and oxidative stress. [30]

Green Gram: Green gram microgreens are typically harvested within 4 to 7 days, using hydroponic or soil-based methods. These microgreens are rich in antioxidants, flavonoids, and phenolic compounds, which have been shown to have various health benefits, including reducing inflammation and improving heart health. [31]

Barley: Barley microgreens are typically harvested within 7 to 14 days, using hydroponic or soil-based methods. These microgreens are rich in vitamins A, C, and E, and minerals such as calcium, iron, and potassium, which have been shown to have various health benefits, including improving digestion and reducing cholesterol levels. [32]

Gram: Gram microgreens are typically harvested within 5 to 10 days, using hydroponic or soil-based methods. These microgreens are rich in antioxidants, phenolic compounds, and flavonoids, which have been shown to have various health benefits, including reducing inflammation and

improving heart health. [33]

Overall, microgreens from these crops are easy to grow and can provide various health benefits when incorporated into one's diet. They can be grown using various methods, making them an ideal crop for both home gardeners and commercial growers.

Easiest Microgreen To Grow

Facts about the easiest microgreens to grow using the hydroponic method.

According to a study published in the journal *Agronomy* in 2018, some of the easiest microgreens to grow using hydroponic methods include *broccoli*, *radish*, *arugula*, and *amaranth*. The study found that these microgreens have a high germination rate and are relatively easy to cultivate in a hydroponic system.[34]

Another study published in the *Journal of the American Society for Horticultural Science* in 2020 examined the growth and nutritional quality of six different microgreens grown hydroponically: basil, broccoli, buckwheat, kale, red cabbage, and wheatgrass. The study found that all six microgreens had high nutrient content and that their growth and nutritional quality were improved when grown using a hydroponic system.[35]

In addition, a study published in the *Journal of Horticultural Science and Biotechnology* in 2018 found that hydroponic cultivation of microgreens had numerous benefits over traditional soil-based methods, including faster growth rates, higher yield, and greater control over the growing environment.

Overall, these studies suggest that hydroponic cultivation of microgreens can be an effective way to grow nutrient-rich plants. Broccoli, radish, arugula, and amaranth are among the easiest microgreens to grow using hydroponic methods, but other microgreens such as basil, buckwheat, kale, and wheatgrass can also be successfully cultivated using this method.

Biostrate

Biostrate is a biodegradable non-woven fabric made from wood pulp that is commonly used as a substrate for plant growth. It is often used in hydroponic systems and is particularly useful for growing microgreens due to its ability to retain moisture and provide a stable growth medium. [36]

Here are some facts and figures about growing microgreens on biostrate medium, supported by references:

Biostrate medium has been found to be an effective substrate for growing microgreens. In a study by Sivakumar et al., (2018), the use of biostrate resulted in higher yield and better growth of microgreens compared to other substrates such as cocopeat and jute felt. [37]

Biostrate medium can also enhance the nutritional quality of microgreens. A study by Amanatidou et al., (2021) found that microgreens grown on biostrate had higher levels of antioxidants and other beneficial nutrients compared to those grown on soil. [38]

The use of biostrate medium can also improve the safety of microgreens. In a study by Vermeulen et al., (2019), the use of biostrate resulted in lower levels of bacterial contamination in microgreens compared to soil-based cultivation. [39]

Biostrate medium can be used to grow a variety of microgreens, including arugula, kale, and radish. In a study by Chen et al., (2020), biostrate was found to be a suitable substrate for growing these microgreens with good yield and quality. [40]

IV. RESEARCH METHOD

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IoT Architecture Design Framework: This stage explains the infrastructure of a three-layer architecture consisting of the sensing, transport, and network layers. [41]

C. Experimental Method

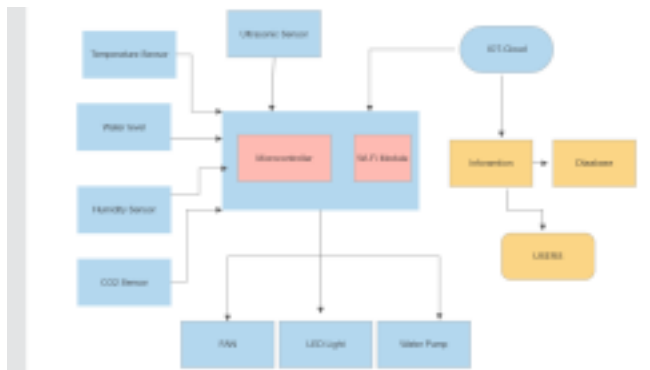
The experimental method involves the process of growing the selected microgreens (barley, gram, wheatgrass, green gram) through a hydroponic method in a controlled environment, specifically in a greenhouse. The aim of this stage is to evaluate the performance of the IoT architecture designed in the previous stage. The growth process of the microgreens will be monitored using sensors placed in the green house and the data will be transmitted to the IoT architecture. The IoT architecture will then analyze the data and provide real-time feedback to the users on the status of the microgreen's growth. This stage will also involve analyzing the data collected to evaluate the effectiveness of the IoT architecture in optimizing the growth of microgreens.

IV. Methodology

In this research, an agricultural technology application was developed in the form of an intelligent system for controlling and monitoring agriculture in a box as an illustration of a closed environment that does not receive sunlight. The main concept of the farming box is to combine several sensors and

actuators with a microcontroller that is integrated with the esp8266 wi-fi module and connects it to a cloud-based information system. The data sent by the microcontroller will be stored into a database on the cloud which is then visualized through a display on a website page that is useful for further analysis.

The process of sending data and control to the system is done automatically. Therefore, in this system, data is only recorded for further research needs or further system development. Not as a consideration for the system in controlling the planting environment automatically, although it does not rule out the possibility to make adjustments manually based on the data obtained. Adjustment of the control variables on the prototype system is done automatically, based on the logic that has been programmed in microcontrollers.



The box will be created by minimizing the light entering, as an example of a closed and low-light environment. At the top, a grow light will be installed as the main light source instead of sunlight. On the side of the box will be installed a fan that acts as an actuator in adjusting the humidity in the system and controlling airflow. The bottom of the box will be the room that holds the water.

A water pump will be placed in the container as an actuator which is used to adjust the water content in the growing media. Plants will be planted using planting media in a tray and placed in a box. Meanwhile, other sensors will be installed in the system, to control each actuator. These sensors include humidity sensors, temperature sensors and moisture sensors.

The development of hardware includes the development of:

A. Microcontroller Box: Create a box that will be a place for the IoT system consisting of a microcontroller, wi-fi module, sensors, actuators, and other required electronic components.

The process starts by putting micro beans into a tray and putting the tray into a container that has a soil moisture sensor. The sensor checks if the soil is moist enough for the mung beans to grow. If the soil is too dry, a motor will turn on and spray water on the plants. Once the soil is moist enough, the motor will turn off.

The system uses two sensors to measure the growth of the plants twice a day and the water level in the tank. The information is shown on a dashboard.

A sensor (DHT-11) checks the temperature and humidity inside the container five times a day.

If it gets too hot, the light will turn off and a fan will turn on to cool the temperature down.

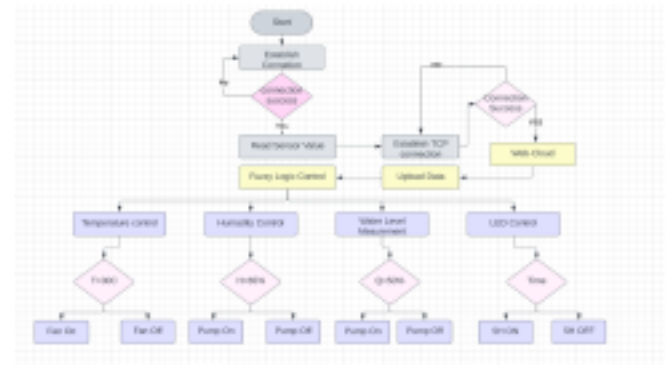
If the temperature decreases, the fan's speed will change and

the light will also adjust.

The same sensor measures the humidity and the fan can be used to control it. Every 4 to 5 hours, the light will turn on to provide proper light for the plants.

The ultrasonic sensor measures plant growth every 12 hours. A rule base is used in fuzzy logic to control the temperature and watering.

Below is the flow diagram of our IoT design.



B. Microgreen Devices: The concept of planting microgreens will be planted in trays.

The growing media is maintained by the system so that it always contains water/moisture for the germination process to be optimal.

Meanwhile, the development of software will be divided into:

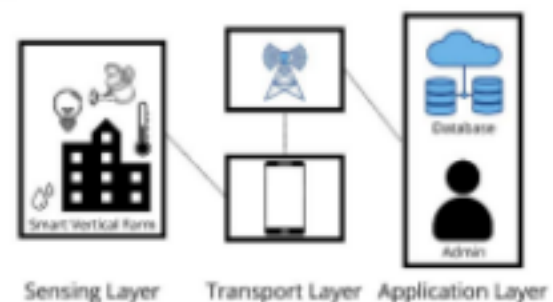


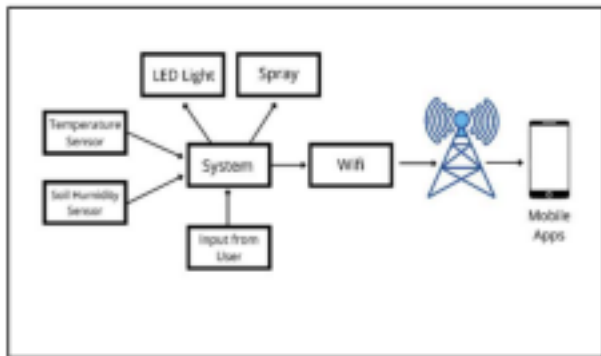
Fig. 10. System Architecture Overview

Making automation programs on the microcontroller.

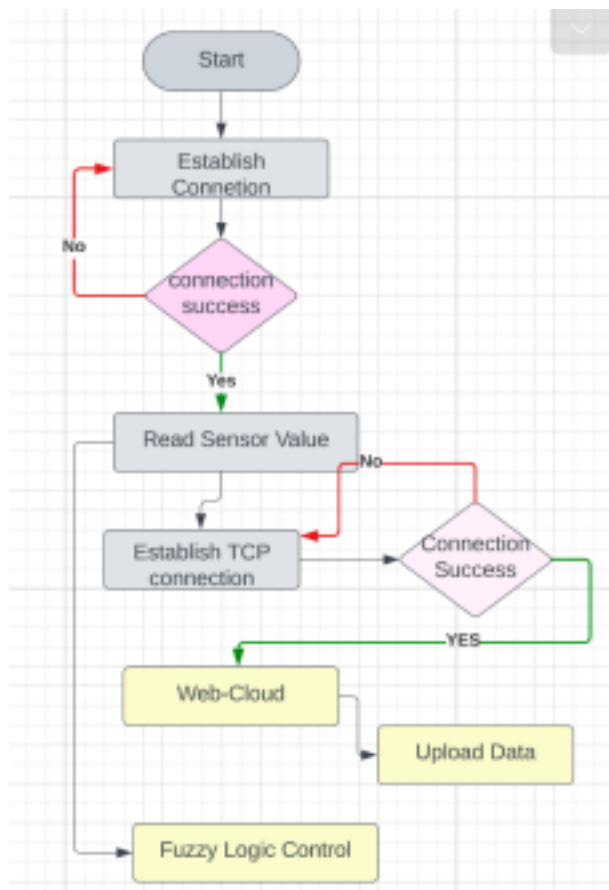
The system design stage involves converting the information model created during the analysis stage into a model that fits with the technology used for implementing the system. For IoT applications, the overall architecture can be divided into three layers: the sensor layer, the transport layer, and the application layer. This architecture is useful for surveillance and control systems, so the system architecture is designed based on this model. Essentially, this means breaking down the system into different layers that work together to achieve the desired functionality.

This is a system that can be used to monitor the growth of microgreens in an indoor vertical farm. It is automated and can operate without any manual input. The system is equipped with sensors that can measure soil moisture and light levels, which are important factors for microgreen growth. These sensors are connected to a database which records the data in real time. This makes it easy to track the progress of microgreen production and identify areas where improvements can be made to increase production. The

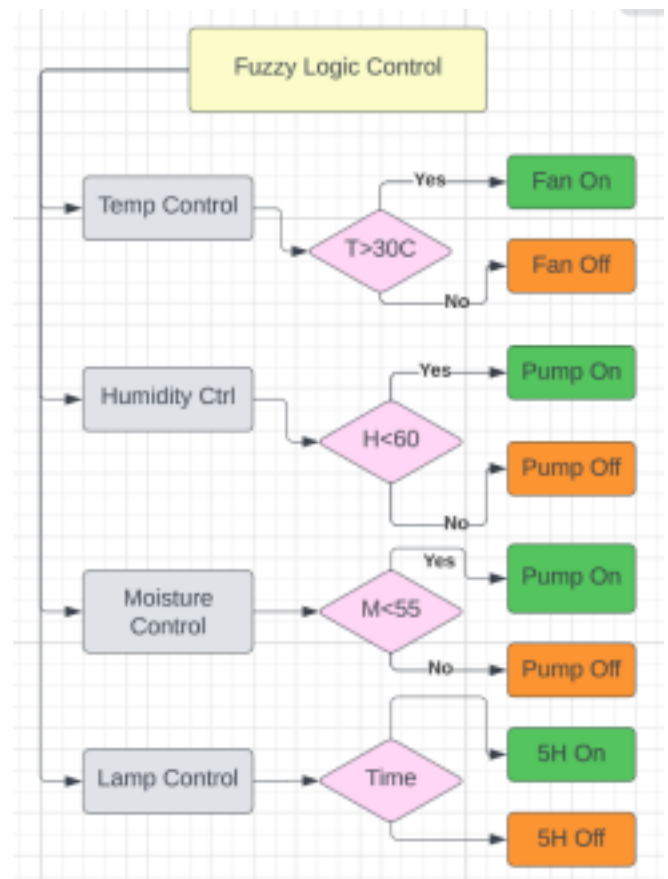
system can be used in remote areas where manual monitoring of soil moisture and light is not feasible. The data recorded in the database can be used to make informed decisions about how to optimize production and increase yields. This information can also be useful for entrepreneurs who are looking to invest in indoor smart farming for microgreens.



B. Process Overview & Fuzzy Logic: The images below show a higher view of the entire process. Which ends the fuzzy logic.



This is the continuation of the previous image. It shows down the logic part of the program from a higher perspective.



V. Mobile UI Design

The mobile application user interface designs were developed to facilitate easy monitoring of plant conditions in a controlled environment. The application enables users to regulate and manage critical parameters such as light intensity, temperature, soil moisture, and automatic watering schedules. The interface design includes intuitive visual representations of plant growth data such as growth rate, yield, and health status. This allows users to easily track plant growth progress and detect any potential issues. The application's user-friendly interface also provides users with the ability to set custom alerts and notifications for any significant changes in the plant growth environment, allowing for prompt and effective intervention. Overall, the mobile application interface design serves as an essential tool for ensuring the optimal growth and productivity of microgreens in a controlled environment. [*]

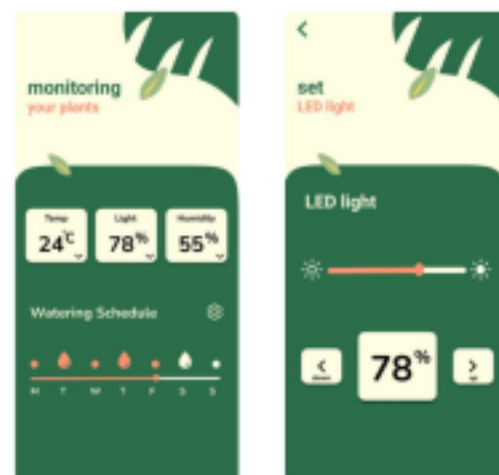


Fig. 3. Mobile UI Design

IV. Result and Discussion

The present study involves the use of a hydroponic system for growing microgreens, namely barley, gram, wheatgrass, and green gram. The system was implemented in a controlled environment within a greenhouse to test the growth of the plants under different environmental conditions. The experiments were conducted in order to determine the optimal conditions required for the growth of the plants.

The first set of experiments was conducted to investigate the effect of temperature and humidity on plant growth. The system was tested for different temperature levels, and it was observed that the system could maintain optimal temperature and humidity levels inside the greenhouse. A cooling fan was turned on when the temperature exceeded the threshold level, and a heating bulb was used to maintain the optimal temperature when the temperature decreased.

The second set of experiments was conducted to observe the effect of photoperiod or light on plant growth. Different lighting conditions were tested, and it was observed that short lighting periods resulted in decreased plant growth, while high lighting conditions resulted in rapid plant growth. The glowing light was turned on automatically as scheduled for a certain time of the day.

The third set of experiments was carried out to determine the effect of water on plant growth. The water level of the tank was monitored using a moisture sensor, and a pump was automatically started when the water level decreased below a certain threshold level. When the moisture level was less than the threshold, the water pump was turned on automatically to water the plants.

Plant growth was monitored using ultrasonic sensors, and the height of the plants was recorded twice a day. When the plant height reached a predefined level, a message was displayed on the web dashboard indicating that the crop was ready for harvest.

The use of a controlled environment within a greenhouse provided optimal conditions for the growth of microgreens. The implementation of the hydroponic system in the greenhouse provided an efficient and sustainable method of growing the plants.

Plant Growth Analytics (Current sample)

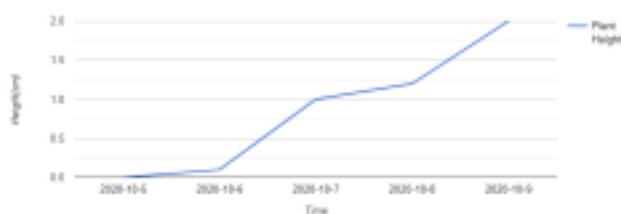


Fig. 3. Plant Growth Analysis

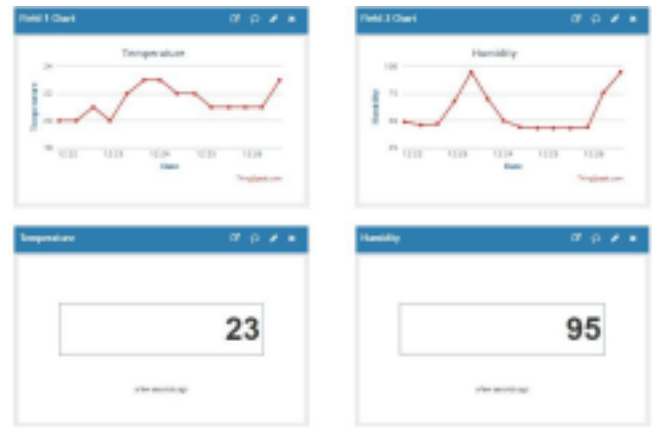


Fig. 3. Temperature & Humidity VS Time

Table 3. Results of the experiment.

Environmental Factor	Parameter	Experiment 1	Experiment 2	Experiment 3
Temperature (°C)	Day	22-24	20-22	22-24
	Night	18-20	16-18	18-20
Humidity (%)		60	65	70
Lighting Hours/Day		16	14	12
Watering Frequency	Times/Day	6	4	6
Plant Height (cm)		6-8	6-8	5-7
Sprout Condition		Healthy	Healthy	Turned yellow

IV. Conclusion

In conclusion, the hydroponic microgreen growing system in a greenhouse can be optimized using various environmental parameters such as temperature, humidity, light, and water. By varying these parameters, we were able to adjust the growing conditions to maintain the optimal growth of different microgreens. The mobile application provided an easy way for users to monitor and control the growing conditions remotely. The use of ultrasonic sensors allowed for real-time monitoring of plant growth and timely harvesting. Overall, this system shows promising results for efficient and controlled microgreen cultivation, which can have potential applications in the food industry and agriculture. Further studies could focus on optimizing the system for specific microgreens and improving the automation process for more efficient and consistent growth.

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